

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

SAFFRON HOMECOMING

After the cheetah's ghar wapsi, it is the Lion of Punjab who has found a retirement home in the BJP. Two-times chief minister Captain Amarinder Singh, his son, daughter and grandson joined the party on September 19. Two ex-MPs and seven ex-MLAs, most of them spent forces in Punjab politics, also accompanied him. The BJP sees Amarinder as a national Sikh voice and expects him to take on the AAP on national issues. He will now have to work with the party's state unit to expand its base in the state and perhaps take orders from leaders half his age. All the Captain, now 80, wants, people close to him say, is to launch daughter Jai Inder Kaur as his wife Parneet Kaur's successor in the family stronghold of Patiala.



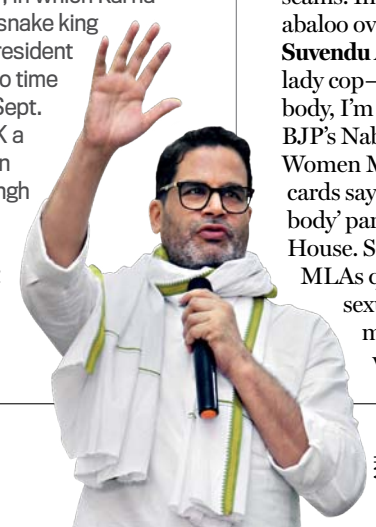
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A SPOT OF RELIEF

While releasing the Namibian cheetahs in Kuno sanctuary in MP, Prime Minister **Narendra Modi** told 'cheetah mitras'—volunteers tasked with raising cheetah awareness—to not allow politicians, their kin or media to see the quarantined animals. The park is officially closed till October 1, and entry needs the chief wildlife warden's permission. Regardless, a top BJP leader, it seems, ensured his followers entered the park almost a week before the release.

Tweet Recrimination

Known for his love-hate relationship with Bihar chief minister and Janata Dal (United) head Nitish Kumar, poll strategist **Prashant Kishor** first raised hopes of a rapprochement when he met Nitish on September 13, and then undid his own effort by tweeting a couplet from poet Ramdhari Singh Dinkar's 'Rashmirathi', in which Karna refuses the help of a snake king to kill Arjuna. Party president Lalan Singh wasted no time releasing a video on Sept. 17, where he called PK a businessman skilled in political gimmicks. Singh also claimed that PK had approached him and Nitish in Delhi but was offered nothing. Now awaiting PK's comeback.



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Penning a Tribute

Tamil Nadu hopes to have its 42-metre-tall monument shaped like **M. Karunanidhi**'s iconic fountain pen ready before the 2026 state polls. Symbolising the former CM's contributions to Tamil literature, the pen pedestal will come up 360 metres off the Marina sands in the Bay of Bengal and close to the DMK patriarch's mausoleum, where a pen was buried with his remains. Taller than the statue of Tamil poet-saint Thiruvalluvar in Kanyakumari, the Rs 81 crore monument has the sword of environment clearance on its head. Will the pen prove mightier?



GENDER CARD GONE WRONG

The monsoon session of the West Bengal assembly was expected to see a recharged Opposition cornering the treasury bench over multiple scams. Instead, there was hullabaloo over opposition leader **Suvendu Adhikari** telling a lady cop—"Don't touch my body, I'm a male"—during the BJP's Nabanna Abhijan yatra. Women MLAs holding placards saying 'Don't touch my body' paraded through the House. Some ruling party MLAs questioned Adhikari's sexuality. In all the melee, the real issue was forgotten.

Kaushik Deka with Anilesh S. Mahajan, Rahul Noronha, Romita Datta, Amarnath K. Menon and Amitabh Srivastava